

The Desi Jihad

Terror now sports an Indian face with ISI training and Taliban indoctrination. It has made the task of weeding out terrorists from locals all the more tough.

■ By Uday Mahurkar and Sandeep Unnithan

Plausible deniability—a political doctrine that originated in the 1950s allowed the US president to deny the covert operations and assassinations carried out by the CIA. The word is as applicable to the shadowy terror games being played out in the subcontinent as it was to the skulduggery of the Cold War. It can, for instance, help explain the new gameplan of Pakistan's Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI) to spread terror throughout the hinterland yet denying any knowledge of it. Ahmedabad was the newest and deadliest in a series of attacks, over the past few years, having claimed about 53 lives and the reappearance of a new group, the Indian Mujahideen.

"While continuing giving financial aid, training and arms assistance to the Lashkar-e-Toiba (LeT), ISI is encouraging it to depend for its operations in Indian territory on Indian Muslims only," says terrorism expert B. Raman. Welcome *desi jihad*. While usual suspects like LeT and the Jaish-e-Mohammed (JeM), which carried out attacks on Parliament and in Ayodhya, have been lying low, the focus in the past few months has now shifted to the Harkat-ul-Jihad-al Islam (HUJI), a shadowy Bangladesh-based jihadi organisation that first shot into prominence with blasts on the Shramjeevi Express and in Varanasi. The explosives used now comprise locally available ammonium nitrate and gelatin sticks instead of RDX that is easily traceable to Pakistan. The Gujarat blasts are believed to have been planned by HUJI and executed by the Indian Mujahideen, which, investigators say, is a new name for the banned Students Islamic Movement of India (SIMI). ISI is believed to

have encouraged HUJI to set up a separate India-specific organisation with recruits solely from the Indian Muslim community.

Secretary of US Department of Homeland Security Michael Chertoff believes the next attack on the US could be carried out by "clean skin" terrorists—European nationals who could fly under the radar. Are the Indian Mujahideen, a purely Indian organisation with no overt Pakistani or Bangladeshi involvement, the "clean skins" the ISI has coveted?

For starters, this is a group that believes in assiduously claiming credit for its misdeeds, always through an email and sometimes with proof and signed by a mysterious "Guru al Hindi". Their voluminous 14-page email sent after the Gujarat attack bizarrely requested "LeT and other organisations not to claim the responsibility for these attacks".

Almost 24 hours after the blasts in Jaipur in May, two TV channels in Delhi had received an anonymous email on behalf of the Indian Mujahideen. Significantly, the message included an authentic picture of one of the cycles alleged to have been used in Jaipur (the number was readable), leading to the possibility

that the Uttar Pradesh and Jaipur blasts were carried out by the same group.

What is the composition of these groups? Following the 2002 Gujarat riots, some of the more radical elements in the Deoband-Tablighi Jamaat and Ahle Hadis tanzeems in Gujarat vowed vengeance. As many as two dozen students, most of them, of course, Kashmiris who were studying in Deobandi madrasas in south Gujarat, fled the madrasas for arms and explosives training in Pakistan soon after the riots. Twelve of these were students of the Deobandi



Indian Mujahideen logo

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